Policy & Procedure: E-Doc Naming Convention

Effective Date
October 1, 2017 (Modified January 1, 2019)

Policy

Each of Partners of the Americas (Partners) departments should follow a clear procedure that addresses the importance of establishing consistent naming practices for electronic files that are prepared for distribution within Partners and with external partners. This procedure should accomplish the following: First, ensure that those receiving the files understand what the files represent. Second, organize and keep track of the files and reference them at a future date. Third, provide a reference to the date and editor of the file (if there is one).

Procedure

Naming e-Documents must contain sufficient information to describe the content of the document. The key to the naming convention is to create a meaningful succinct description. Keep file names short and relevant.

1. When naming files, it is important to always include the following information:
   - Funder / Organization name / Project (if applicable)
   - Document content summary
   - Date prepared or edited (year, month, day)
   - Initials of person preparing or editing if applicable, or status of doc (eg. Draft, final, etc.).

2. The following detail includes an example on how to properly name a proposal file.

   i. First, it is important to include the "funder / organization name / project" first (if applicable). For example, when preparing the master narrative of a Department of State (DOS) Funded proposal for Youth Ambassadors, the file could start with:

   DOS YA

   ii. Second, the file name will also need to include the content of the document. In this case, we are naming a master narrative so the file will be named as follows:

   DOS YA Master Narrative **or** DOS YA Narrative, etc.

   iii. Third, the file will need to also include the date the document is prepared or modified. The date should first include the four digit year (all four digits are used to avoid confusion with the two-digit month), followed by the two digit month, and finally the two digit day. Both month and day should always use two digits, even for the first 1 – 9 dates. The date should only consist of numbers and it should include hyphens (or periods) between the year, month, and day. For example:

   DOS YA Master Narrative 2016-02-17

   Placing all of the digits is important, along with the correct sequence – year, month, day –

so that when files are sorted, all similar documents will be paired together and the files will be arranged in chronological order by year.

REMEMBER: Once you receive a document with a date, if you edit the document on a later date, rename the document with the new date.

iv. Lastly, if the document is edited, the initials of the editor should be included. For example, if the document was edited by Jane Doe, the file would be named as follows:

DOS YA Master Narrative 2016-02-17 jd

If this same document is edited again on the same day by John Smith, it would be named as follows:

DOS YA Master Narrative 2016-02-17 jd js

If, instead, the same document is edited a week later, for example on the 25th, by John Smith, it would be named as follows:

DOS YA Master Narrative 2016-02-25 jd js

v. Once a final version of a document is completed, the initials may be deleted and replaced with the word "final." For example:

DOS YA Master Narrative 2016-02-25 FINAL

It is extremely important to do this – in particular if there are various versions and these are documents that are considered official and given to a donor or some external agency.

3. Here are some other good examples of how documents can be named:

KLG Budget Draft 2014-03-01 jrm.xls (for a Kellogg budget proposal)
KLG Proposal Prep Timeline 2014-03-12 mc.doc
KLG Person Loading Chart Final.doc

USAID F2F Award letter 2015-08.doc
USAID F2F Program Description 2015-06 Final.doc

SENA 100K Cover Page Cost Proposal 2017.doc
SENA 100K Attach5 List of Contacts 2017.doc

4. And now, here are some bad examples of documents that have actually been named (can you tell what they are for? Which program do they refer to?):

Masternarrative ver2 june15.doc
Draft Exec Summary March 21.doc
List of persons interviewed for situational analysis.doc
DETAILED_BUDGET_INTERNAL_FINAL.xls